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THEATRE ARTS

DRAMATIC CRITICISM

Approaches to Drama: Aristotle to the Present

A ZikShare teaching unit, written for this shelf

The main critical traditions and what each one lets you see: Aristotelian, historical, Marxist, psychoanalytic, semiotic, post-colonial and performance criticism.

WHAT THIS UNIT COVERS

- Aristotle
- historical
- Marxist
- semiotics
- post-colonial

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The classical inheritance

Aristotle's Poetics gives criticism its first vocabulary: plot, character, thought, diction, song and spectacle; reversal, recognition, hamartia and catharsis. Whatever you think of the theory, the vocabulary is still how plays are described.

Horace, Sidney, Dryden, Lessing and Schlegel argued about the rules that were derived from Aristotle - the unities, the mixing of tragedy and comedy, the status of Shakespeare - and each argument tells you what its period thought theatre was for.

History and society

The historical critic reads a play as an event in its own theatre and society: what stage it was written for, what the audience expected, what the censors allowed. The Marxist critic reads it as an argument about power, class and ideology, asking whose interests the form serves.

Both approaches guard against the belief that a play means only what it means to us. Both can also explain a play away: not every line is a symptom of its century.

The unconscious and the sign

Psychoanalytic criticism reads the play as a structure of desire, repression and repetition, and it is strongest on character and on the imagery a play cannot stop using. Semiotics reads the performance as a system of signs - the set, the light, the gesture, the tone - and asks how meaning is made in the theatre rather than on the page.

Semiotics is the most useful of the modern approaches for a director, because it describes exactly the materials a director controls.

Post-colonial and performance criticism

Post-colonial criticism asks how a play positions Africa, the coloniser and the audience, and it has been the dominant approach in Nigerian drama since the 1980s: Soyinka's metaphysics, Osofisan's politics and the feminist critique of both are part of it.

Performance criticism reads the event rather than the text: the audience, the space, the body, the night. It is the approach that takes the theatre seriously as theatre, and it is the one a student production most needs.

Reading closely: a practical sequence

Whatever approach you choose, begin with the text in front of you. Read the scene twice: once for what happens, once for how it is made. Then write four lists: what each character wants, what each says, what each does, and what the scene withholds. Most critical arguments begin in the gap between the second and the third list.

Then place the scene: where it sits in the play, what the audience knows at that point, and what the scene is doing to the play's shape. A scene that seems dull in isolation is often a hinge, and a scene that seems brilliant is often a set piece that stops the story.

Only then bring the theory. Use it to ask a question the text cannot answer by itself, not to prove a conclusion you had before you read. A criticism that could be written without the play is not criticism of the play.

The vocabulary you need

Learn a working set of terms precisely: plot, story, action, beat, objective, obstacle, turning point, reversal, recognition, climax, resolution, exposition, subtext, aside, soliloquy, dramatic irony, stock character, type, stereotype, protagonist, antagonist, chorus, catharsis.

Then use them to describe rather than to decorate. "Dramatic irony" is not a compliment; it names the gap between what the character knows and what the audience knows. A criticism that uses the terms accurately can be argued with, which is the whole point.

Exercises

1. Read one short play through two of these approaches and write a paragraph from each.
2. Take a production decision and explain what a semiotic critic would say about it.
3. Write a post-colonial reading of a Nigerian play, with two quotations from the text.

Where to read more

Aristotle, Poetics (c. 335 BCE)

Keir Elam, The Semiotics of Theatre and Drama (1980)

Marvin Carlson, Theories of the Theatre (1993)

Tejumola Olaniyan, Scars of Conquest/Masks of Resistance (1995)

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